

Thinking beyond a polarized world: why multiplexity matters

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The idea of a ‘multiplex world order’, hence ‘multiplexity’, originated from my 2014 work *The end of American world order*,¹ which sought to reconceptualize international relations by looking beyond traditional frameworks of polarity (multipolar, bipolar, unipolar, etc.). Such an order is defined by five features:

- A world without a hegemon, shaped by the relative decline of the United States/western power and the US-led world order, with the corresponding rise of ‘the rest’ (the global South);
- The proliferation of consequential actors: great powers, states, international and regional institutions, corporations, extremist and criminal groups, civil society networks and people empowered by social media;
- Changing forms of interconnectedness: trade, finance, production networks, infrastructure development, climate change and migration;
- Growing cultural and political diversity: no ‘end of history’, but ‘multiple modernities’. The coexistence of democracy, authoritarianism, communism and extremism; and
- The pluralization of cooperation and governance: G-Plus (government-plus) leadership.

An important clarification should be made before moving further. While the concept can be understood with the metaphor of a multiplex cinema—where the audience has a choice of movie genres, featuring a variety of actors, plots, producers and directors, I also drew on other points of reference of multiplexity.² The term was first used in mid-sixteenth-century mathematics

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¹ Amitav Acharya, *The end of American world order* (Cambridge, UK: Polity, 2014 and 2018).

² More recently, I have used the Netflix streaming service, which also gives the audience a choice of movies and actors as a metaphor for multiplexity, but there is a big difference: while watching Netflix is primarily an individual exercise, it can be watched from the comfort of one’s home, or the screen of one’s smartphone. Multiplex, on the other hand, captures a wider social gathering and a variety of audience members: people gathered under the same roof and watching simultaneously: Amitav Acharya @amitavacharya via X, ‘One could also visualize multiplex as Netflix ...’, 29 June 2025, <https://x.com/AmitavAcharya/status/1939232596606755025?s=20>. (Unless otherwise noted at point of citation, all URLs cited in this article were accessible on 3 Feb. 2026.)

and meant ‘having many folds’ or ‘many parts’. Multiplexity has also been used in the telecommunications field, where it replaced transmitting signals or messages from a central point of origin to doing so interactively between multiple transmission points simultaneously. In short, a multiplex world order has ‘many folds’ and ‘many parts’ that all matter. It is a decentralized and diversified world in which actors, state and non-state, established and new powers from the North and the South, interact in an interdependent manner to produce an order based on a plurality of ideas and approaches.

This meaning makes the multiplex especially apt as a metaphor for conceptualizing the emerging world order. At the same time, it is not a purely geopolitical concept: it can be and has been applied to many other fields, such as political economy, moral norms and cultural diffusion. As the introduction to this special section of *International Affairs* clarifies, multiplexity inheres both multiplicity and complexity, thus enabling a richer understanding of how power is used, negotiated and undermined in a pluralistic world.³

Multiplexity thus conceived is an analytical alternative to polarity-centred concepts. There has been much debate about the nature of world order after the passing of the postwar liberal international order (LIO). Most analysts have argued that it would be a multipolar world, while a few—such as Chinese scholar Yan Xuetong and American scholar Jennifer Lind—see bipolarity.⁴ Yet bipolarity, multipolarity or unipolarity make sense only if we count the number of powers defined materially (by economics and military capacity) and compare individual national power. But if we measure not just traditional notions of stand-alone power, but also interaction capacity and variations in regional influence, a much more complex picture emerges.⁵ While a multiplex order may feature a multipolar distribution of material power, it is shaped by many more features and drivers, including ideational and normative elements. While traditional notions of polarity are based almost exclusively on the role of great powers (‘poles’), multiplexity takes into consideration many other consequential actors: regional powers, NGOs, multinational corporations and transnational networks, and especially the agency of global South nations, including non-great powers.

The multiplex framework also addresses limitations of other concepts in the existing International Relations (IR) vocabulary for studying world order.⁶

³ Nora Fisher-Onar and Indrajit Roy, ‘Multiplexity 2.0: power and pluralism in the post-liberal age’, *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 319–335, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iia027>.

⁴ Yan Xuetong, ‘Becoming strong: the new Chinese foreign policy’, *Foreign Affairs*, 100: 4, 2021, pp. 40–7, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/united-states/2021-06-22/becoming-strong>; Jennifer Lind, ‘Back to bipolarity: How China’s rise transformed international politics’, *International Security* 49: 2, 2024, pp. 7–54, https://doi.org/10.1162/isec_a_00494.

⁵ Amitav Acharya, Antoni Esteveordal and Louis Goodman, ‘Multipolar or multiplex? Interaction capacity, global cooperation and world order’, *International Affairs* 99: 6, 2023, pp. 2339–65, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iia242>. This article measured global interaction patterns quantitatively by surveying international treaties signed between 1945 and 2017; it pointed to the growing multiplexity of global cooperation, not multipolarity.

⁶ Niall Ferguson, ‘The end of power’, *Wall Street Journal*, 21 June 2004, <https://www.wsj.com/articles/SB108778528181442638>; Richard N. Haass, ‘The age of nonpolarity: what will follow US dominance’, *Foreign Affairs* 87: 3, 2008, pp. 44–56, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/united-states/2008-05-03/>.

Terms like ‘apolar’ (coined by Niall Ferguson) and ‘nonpolar’ (Richard Haass) fail to convey the complex power asymmetries characterizing today’s international system. While ‘multi-order’ (Trine Flockhart) and the older notion of ‘polycentric’ (Elinor Ostrom and Joseph S. Nye, Jr), acknowledge fragmentation or decentralization of world order, they seem to envisage great power spheres of influence, or treat connections among orders or centres as mere addendums, rather than central features. The multiplex concept, by contrast, places interaction capacity at centre stage, making connectivity itself the defining characteristic of the contemporary order. The concept of ‘multi-nodal’, advanced by Brantly Womack, comes closer by emphasizing nodes and their connectivity, yet it leaves out crucial dimensions: ideas, norms and their relationship with power structures. Multiplexity emerges as the broadest concept, capable of subsuming others while recognizing that the whole exceeds the sum of its parts.

Multiplexity is not an idealistic notion. It captures the ongoing decentring of world politics and the prevalence of competition as well as cooperation.⁷ At the same time, multiplexity takes us well beyond great power centrality or ‘poles’, ‘centres’ and ‘nodes’. It explicitly acknowledges the agency of a wider variety of actors and interactions. In this, it is unlike other conceptions of world order that focus mainly on the global level and are heavily weighted in favour of a single dominant power, or a small number of major players—as in the G7 or the idea of a US–China G2. Instead, multiplexity embraces ‘G-Plus’ leadership (governments plus non-state actors) and governance mechanisms that operate within a post-hegemonic paradigm that recognizes a plurality of actors, issues and mechanisms. Leadership is issue-specific and pluralized, with non-state actors playing an important role. Agency in a multiplex world involves not just great powers, but also middle powers, regional bodies and non-state actors. The latter may include humanitarian agencies, scientific or knowledge communities, the private sector or social movements, or individuals, including those empowered by social media. While multipolarity concerns power distribution, multiplexity captures how different actors embed themselves within webs of relationships that are simultaneously independent and interdependent.

A useful way to understand multiplexity, going back to the previously mentioned usage of the term in the field of telecommunications, would be to view it as the opposite of ‘mirroring’. In mirroring, data from one central point of origin are copied to multiple devices, whereas in multiplexity, data from multiple points of origin are written to many places simultaneously.

age-nonpolarity; ‘China not trying to destroy American system: Joseph Nye,’ *Global Times*, 4 Nov. 2019, <https://www.globaltimes.cn/page/201911/1168892.shtml>; Trine Flockhart, ‘The coming multi-order world’, *Contemporary Security Policy* 37: 1, 2016, pp. 3–30, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13523260.2016.1150053>; Elinor Ostrom, ‘Beyond markets and states: polycentric governance of complex economic systems’, *American Economic Review* 100: 3, 2010, pp. 641–72, <https://doi.org/10.1257/aer.100.3.641>; Brantly Womack, ‘Strategic principles for co-existence in a multinodal world’, *China International Strategy Review*, vol. 6, 2024, pp. 22–38, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s42533-024-00155-8>.

⁷ Indrajit Roy, ‘Southern multilateralism: complementary competition *vis-à-vis* the liberal international order’, *Global Perspectives* 3: 1, 2022, <https://doi.org/10.1525/gp.2022.39589>.

This distinction could be central in conceptualizing multiplex world order and global governance today. It means that world order is more decentred, without a single central source of authority and command, and—aside from a global institution like the United Nations—there are also regional or inter-regional centres or transmitters of ideas and policies to support global governance. In a multiplex world order, ideas and approaches to peace, development and stability do not emerge from a singular powerful source, and then simply get ‘mirrored’ or copied into other places. Rather, they have multiple points of origin, global, regional and local, which nonetheless intersect and interact.

Multiplexity is not a fixed or final outcome, but a dynamic, contested and non-linear process that can vary across issue areas. The introduction to this special section refers to a transition from multiplexity 1.0 to multiplexity 2.0;⁸ as this suggests, the concept sheds fresh light on a variety of issues in global affairs, old and new. Thus, it looks beyond old issues of security or geopolitics or trade and development, and helps to make sense of interactions around new issues, such as artificial intelligence (AI) and outer space. It recognizes the importance of ideas, norms and soft power and captures the role of non-state actors, the importance of historical time (what I would call four-dimensional reality) and the possibility of a more radical transformation of world order. Drawing on the articles included in this special section and the broader research project behind it, the remainder of this afterword highlights four key dimensions of multiplexity: political-economic, technological, critical and temporal. To be sure, these dimensions are not exhaustive—one could also add strategic multiplexity that refers to the diffusion of military capabilities among states and non-state actors, or cultural multiplexity that underscores the spread of popular culture and cuisine—but the four dimensions elaborated below do capture the global diversification of ideas and agency in the contemporary world order.

Political-economic multiplexity

Political-economic multiplexity sheds new light on the shifts in power and leadership in issue areas such as globalization, trade and development. While western dominance of the global economy has not disappeared, it has been met with growing southern agency in global economic development.⁹ Here, agency rests not just on the material power of global South nations, but also on their moral claims about economic justice and sustainable development. For example, the idea of human development, which considers not GDP growth rates, but the expansion of human resources and capabilities, with attention to primary education and public health, emerged from the work of thinkers from the global South such as Mahbub ul Haq and Amartya Sen. New forms of development cooperation, undertaken within the framework of the now

⁸ Roy and Fisher-Onar, ‘Multiplexity 2.0’.

⁹ Indrajit Roy, ‘Asserting southern agency: the moralistic realism of multiplexity’, *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 337–62, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiag001>.

expanded BRICS,¹⁰ as well as the China-initiated Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, show that the global South countries are not just 'smug proponents of liberal hegemony'¹¹ following approaches laid out by western powers, but are deploying their own normative principles and exerting their own agency to stress infrastructure and sustainable development.

Political-economic multiplexity directs attention to the role of China and other emerging powers. Analysing this shift may lead to differences of perspective. One view is that such challenges from emerging powers would not significantly dent western dominance. On the contrary, the China challenge has sparked a 'geoeconomic turn' from the West—especially the US—to maintain its centrality.¹² This view has some merit. The decline of the West and the rise of the rest are not uniform across issue areas and should not be overstated. Yet broader recent trends in global growth and South–South trade paint a different picture, one that points to the eventual end of West-led globalization. Not only have China and India emerged among the top five economies in the world; according to one estimate, trade among developing countries, or South–South trade, had reached an estimated 39.6 per cent of global trade in 2025, versus 31.5 per cent in 1995. Indeed, if one includes China, South–South trade represented 55.6 per cent of world trade in 2025 versus 38.3 per cent in 1995.¹³

Technological multiplexity

Multiplexity is a particularly useful tool to study the emergence of norms and interaction capacities in emerging technologies such as those in the issue areas of outer space and AI. Technological multiplexity holds that norms and approaches emerging in such issue areas do not constitute a single set, created by a singular hegemonic actor. Rather, they constitute a 'menu of choices' developed by multiple actors 'that both intersect and diverge from those of others'. Nations that do not have the capacity to produce AI technology or norms can select from the menu—as audiences do in a multiplex theatre—thereby demonstrating their agency. This makes multiplexity a dynamic and highly networked process. Moreover, comparing different AI norms, their creation and modes of diffusion gives a sense not only of variation, but also of their similarities and 'entanglements'.¹⁴

¹⁰ The BRICS grouping was founded in 2009 by Brazil, Russia, India and China. South Africa joined in 2010; Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran and the United Arab Emirates were admitted in 2024. Indonesia joined in 2025, and at the time of writing Saudi Arabia was considering the BRICS invitation.

¹¹ Roy, 'Asserting southern agency'.

¹² Lukas Linsi and Naná de Graaff, 'Decline of the West? An IPE perspective on the multiplex world order and the "geoeconomic turn"', *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 363–87, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiaf274>.

¹³ Kevin P. Gallagher and José Antonio Ocampo, 'Beyond America First: southern strategies for a multipolar economic order', *American Prospect*, 27 Nov. 2025, <https://prospect.org/2025/11/27/beyond-america-first>.

¹⁴ J. P. Singh, Manpriya Dua and Amarda Shehu, 'Diffusion of power and multiplexed governance: evolving networks and clusters for global governance of AI infrastructures', *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 409–34, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiaq024>.

Multiplexity can illuminate patterns of interaction in other high-technology areas, such as outer space. Here, the dominance of the United States, through both official and commercial means, persists, attesting to the fact that the degree of multiplexity is more limited in these issue areas. At the same time, rising powers have become increasingly important actors, contributing at least to regional cooperation in these areas, with both the European Space Agency and African Space Agency providing examples of such cooperation.¹⁵ This implies that multiplexity can be used to study competition as well as cooperation, highlighting regionalism as an important component of multiplexity.

Critical multiplexity

Critical multiplexity poses an alternative to state-centric views of world order. The proliferation of consequential actors—‘good’ and ‘bad’—is a central aspect of the multiplex concept.

In a multiplex world, the making and management of order is more diversified and decentralized, with the involvement of established and emerging powers, states, global and regional bodies, and transnational non-state actors. The latter include good global civil-society groups and norm entrepreneurs, and villains such as al-Qaeda, drug lords, people smugglers, and greedy corporations (although corporations can go either way).¹⁶

Hence, multiplexity takes into consideration the role of extremists, such as Islamic State (IS) and white power terrorists.¹⁷ On the other side of the coin are social movements as agents of positive change, which is central to the idea of ‘critical multiplexity’.¹⁸ This notion extends the agents of multiplexity well beyond governments of the global South and radically focuses on non-state actors, social movements, and peoples—not just states or powers—as catalysts of a more robust and deeper transformation of world order.

Here, I wish to make a point of clarification: although liberal conceptions of world order recognize the role of social movements, multiplexity has never rested on liberal foundations only; in fact, its central purpose was to challenge the idea of the LIO, recognizing the space for social movements and peoples as autonomous agents, rather than as adjuncts to the self-proclaimed ‘liberal West’ led by the US or western European nations. Critical multiplexity takes the role of social movements farther. This is in a sense similar to critical approaches to IR theory; indeed, ‘critical multiplexity’ draws inspiration from postcolonial notions and Gramscian theories, the latter giving centre stage to people’s resistance to hegemony at national and global levels.

¹⁵ Dimitrios Strokos, ‘China, the “rise of the rest” and the remaking of the international space order in a multiplex world’, *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 389–408, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiaf275>.

¹⁶ Acharya, *The end of American world order*, pp. 7–8.

¹⁷ Nicholas Chan, ‘Extremist timelines: interrogating the politics of time in twenty-first-century violent anti-liberal movements’, *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 481–502, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiaf237>.

¹⁸ Sasikumar Sundaram and Inderjeet Parmar, ‘Towards critical multiplexity in International Relations’, *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 435–54, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiaf276>.

Multiplexity is a broad umbrella that subsumes both reformist and radical approaches to change. It challenges existing conceptions of world order to be more inclusive of the ideas and contributions of non-western actors, whether state or non-state. This means giving a central place to anti-colonial movements and progressive coalitions of post-colonial states such as the 1955 Bandung Conference (Asian–African Conference) and anti-racist movements that depended not on foreign elites, but also on local struggles of people, such as that of the African National Congress during the apartheid era in South Africa.

Moreover, while there can be ‘elite co-optation’ in multiplexity—whereby ‘new elites are (often willingly) integrated into existing institutional networks’,¹⁹ this does not always succeed in upholding the power of the West. It did not work in the case of the BRICS members, whom the LIO was supposed to co-opt. While the world-views of BRICS members and other emerging powers do overlap with liberal ideas of global order, they also want to reform the existing world order so as to enhance the participation of non-western nations and accommodate different political and economic systems, rather than supporting neo-liberal market capitalism.

Here, one is reminded of Robert Cox’s well-known distinction between ‘problem-solving’ and ‘critical’ theories of IR:²⁰ the former strive for change within the existing world order, whereas the latter call for radical transformation beyond the existing world order. Perhaps it can be said that multiplexity transcends the binary of problem-solving reform and critical transformation, favouring initial reform as a pathway to long-term transformation.

Temporal multiplexity

Temporal multiplexity presents multiplexity as a four-dimensional concept. While standard conceptions of world order are three-dimensional, in the sense that they correspond to distribution of power (height), extent or geographic scope (length) and robustness and legitimacy (depth), adding the fourth dimension of time ‘generates a more accurate picture of our past and future world order than the singular and domineering perspective of the liberal hegemony idea’.²¹ Ahistorical or presentist notions of world order cannot capture change and transformation. In a multiplex conceptualization, world order is not about ‘spatial arrangement of power’: it is ‘not only erected and contested in *space*, but also in *time*’.²²

Attention to time can mean several things. It means invoking the past to legitimize ideas of world order. The rise of civilizational narratives in the

¹⁹ Sundaram and Parmar, ‘Towards critical multiplexity in IR’.

²⁰ Robert W. Cox, ‘Social forces, states and world orders: beyond International Relations theory’, *Millennium* 10: 2, 1981, pp. 126–55, <https://doi.org/10.1177/03058298810100020501>.

²¹ Acharya, *The end of American world order*, 2014, pp. 9–11.

²² Peter Marcus Kristensen and Fabrício H. Chagas-Bastos, ‘Time and the multiplex order’, *International Affairs* 102: 2, 2026, pp. 455–79, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iia026> (emphasis in original).

discourses of the leaders of China, India, Russia, Turkey and the United States (under Donald Trump and J. D. Vance) shows that leaders often link their conception of world order to past glories or humiliations. But this time-travelling also applies to non-state actors, including radical groups. A temporal element in extremist politics is an important aspect of multiplexity.²³ Radical groups often seek legitimacy by going back in time; for example, the use of black flags and robes by IS militants 'to signal a return to the Prophet's time', and the tactics of white supremacists commonly invoking the Crusades or the Nazi era of Germany to justify their cause.²⁴

The temporal dimension also symbolizes the 'essential transience of orders ... draw[ing] attention to their points of origin and ending'.²⁵ It means accepting that world orders like empires, or nation-states, rise and fall. This has major implications for academics and policy-makers pondering the passing of the US-led LIO. Not long ago, that order was presented as an enduring idea; it was viewed as lasting and capable of co-opting challengers like China and India. Yet the crisis of the LIO took most western analysts by surprise and the order is now gone, for the most part, under Trump's second presidency of the US.

To be sure, recognizing time as the fourth dimension does not mean bringing the past back in conceiving the next world order. To some extent, multiplexity is a unique form of world order. The concurrent rise of a number of states, including independent non-western powers, in different geographic locations but interacting on a regular and sustained basis, has not happened before. But history offers useful lessons; it points to a range of possibilities for organizing world order after a period of change. It points to the existence of large and fairly durable international systems without a hegemonic anchor (such as in the Indian Ocean, or in parts of Eurasia). It tells us that non-western civilizations have been major players in world orders.²⁶ Hence, highlighting non-western agency while imagining a connected if diversified global future captures the novelty of the multiplexity idea.²⁷

Conclusion

Multiplexity in its varied dimensions—political-economic, technological, critical and temporal—challenges the traditional conception of world order, highlighting in particular the growing diversity of power, norms and leadership in global interactions and the agency of state and non-state actors. While

²³ Chan, 'Extremist timelines'.

²⁴ Chan recalls the case of Anders Breivik, the Norwegian terrorist who murdered 77 people in attacks in Oslo and on the island of Utøya on 22 July 2011. Breivik envisaged the year 2083 as the final point of a European take-over by extremists because it marked the 400th anniversary of the victory of European forces over Ottoman forces besieging Vienna: Chan, 'Extremist timelines'.

²⁵ Acharya, *The end of American world order*, p. 11.

²⁶ Amitav Acharya. *The once and future world order: why global civilization can survive the decline of the West* (New York: Basic Books, 2025).

²⁷ Acharya, *The end of American world order*, 2014; Acharya, *The once and future world order*.

paying due attention to the strengths and weaknesses of southern power and agency, the real usefulness of the concept lies not so much in relation to the question whether the world is becoming less dominated by the West, but how the concept can be deployed as an analytical tool to study the transition occurring towards a more pluralistic and diverse world order.

The multiplex concept's strength also lies in its broad applicability across time and domains—security, political economy and development alike. It provides analytical tools for understanding contemporary global politics that acknowledge complexity without sacrificing coherence. Multiplexity can provide an analytical tool to understand variations and changes in world order. It allows us to study the role of power distribution as well as interaction patterns across multiple issues areas beyond geopolitics. It captures the role of both hard and soft power and ideational as well as material dimensions of world order. It considers the role of the global South as well as that of the global North.

Not only does further research and analysis about multiplexity help us to understand key trends of continuity and change in world order, it can also be useful as an incubator of theories of world order and global governance. Although not a positivist theory like the mainstream US approach to IR, it can generate such causal propositions and identify conditions under which cooperation in a more diverse and pluralistic world can take place. While multiplexity is partly a structural theory, in the sense that it holds that a decentred and pluralistic structure of world order can influence stability and development, it views the international system as neither anarchic nor hierarchic, but agent-centric. International power structures such as unipolarity, bipolarity or multipolarity cannot by themselves generate cooperation without the agency of states and non-state actors, especially those from the global South. Multiplexity also points to the importance and likelihood of cooperation at the regional level. The idea of multiplexity thus enriches, as well as challenges, traditional conceptions of world order, even as debates abound over the extent to which it defines the present world order and its practical applications.